

JJ PREMIER GROUP

GUIDE NO. 04

Homestead, Save Our Homes and portability, explained

Why the tax on a listing isn't yours, what homestead takes off your bill, and what you can carry to the next house.

BY JESSICA GARZA · UPDATED OCTOBER 2, 2026 · 10 MIN READ

JJ PREMIER GROUP · COLDWELL BANKER REALTY

How to use this guide

Read this guide once, start to finish. Then use the worksheet at the end when you look at a house.

Tax rules change, and voters may change them again in November 2026. Each part of this guide says where its facts come from. Before you count on a number for one house, check with the county property appraiser.

Inside this guide

01 The tax on a listing is the seller's bill

02 What homestead is

03 Save Our Homes: the cap

04 The reset: what happens the January after you buy

05 Portability: what you can carry to the next house

06 Four dates in the tax year

07 What voters decide in November 2026

08 Before you buy: your tax homework

09 Your tax notes for one house

As you read, keep coming back to three questions

1. What will my first full-year bill be?
2. Did I file for homestead by March 1?
3. Can I carry my cap from my old Florida home?

01

The tax on a listing is the seller's bill

A listing shows what the seller pays now. Your bill will be figured a different way, starting the January after you buy.

Picture two houses on the same street. They're the same size and the same age. One owner has lived there for twenty years. The other bought last year. The long-time owner pays far less tax. The houses are alike, so why?

In Florida, two things lower the bill for people who live in their home. One is an exemption. It takes some value off the top. The other is a cap. It slows how fast the taxed value can rise. Both belong to the owner, not to the house.

When the house sells, both come off. On the January 1 after you buy, the county sets the taxed value back to the home's market value. Your own exemption and cap then start from there, if you file for them.

So don't budget on the listing. Budget on what the house is worth now. The state's own guide for new Florida owners says it plainly. Many new owners are surprised when their bill is higher than the last owner's.

FIG. 01 · TWO BILLS

The seller's bill and yours are figured on different numbers

Read each side. The seller's side ends at closing. Your side starts the next January 1.

THE SELLER'S BILL WAS FIGURED ON

Years of capped value, minus their exemption

- A taxed value that could rise only a little each year, for as long as they owned the home
- Minus their homestead exemption
- None of it stays with the house

YOUR FIRST FULL-YEAR BILL IS FIGURED ON

The home's market value on the next January 1

1. The value the county sets on the January 1 after you buy
2. Minus your own exemption, if you file by March 1
3. Your cap starts the year after that

Source: Florida Department of Revenue, PT-107, Your taxes vs. the previous owner's taxes; PT-112, Change or transfer of ownership

02

What homestead is

Homestead is a tax break for the home you live in. It takes value off the top before your tax is figured.

The home must be your permanent home on January 1. Then you apply with the county property appraiser by March 1. In Manatee and Sarasota you can apply online. Once it's granted, it stays on the home each year while you live there.

The break comes in two parts. The first part takes 25,000 dollars off the home's value. That part counts against every tax on your bill, school taxes too.

The second part takes a bit more off. In 2026 it's 26,411 dollars. It only counts on the value above 50,000 dollars. And it skips school taxes. This part rises a little each January with inflation.

If you miss March 1, the law allows a late application only in a few cases. The appraiser decides. Don't count on it. Miss the date, and you pay the full bill for a year.

FIG. 02 · THE TWO PARTS

What homestead takes off a home's value

Read from the bottom up. The lowest value is at the bottom. Green and blue bands are exempt.

THE HOME'S ASSESSED VALUE, LOWEST AT THE BOTTOM



ABOVE 76,411 DOLLARS

Taxed

The rest of the value is taxed, after the cap in the next section.

50,000 TO 76,411 DOLLARS

Exempt from all but school taxes

The second part. It's 26,411 dollars in 2026 and rises with inflation.

25,000 TO 50,000 DOLLARS

Taxed

No exemption on this slice.

THE FIRST 25,000 DOLLARS

Exempt from every tax

School taxes too.

EXEMPT FROM EVERY TAX EXEMPT FROM ALL BUT SCHOOL TAXES TAXED

This drawing uses the 2026 amounts. The second part changes each January.

Source: Florida Department of Revenue, PT-113, Examples of applying homestead; Additional homestead exemption adjustment (2026); Florida Statutes 196.031(1)

03

Save Our Homes: the cap

Once you have homestead, the value your tax is figured on can rise only a little each year. That's the cap.

Every home has two values on the county's books. The first is the market value. The appraiser calls it the just value. It can jump a lot in a hot year.

The second is the assessed value. That's the one your tax is figured on. With homestead, it can rise by no more than 3 percent a year. If prices in general rose less than that, it rises by that smaller amount. In 2026 the cap is 2.7 percent.

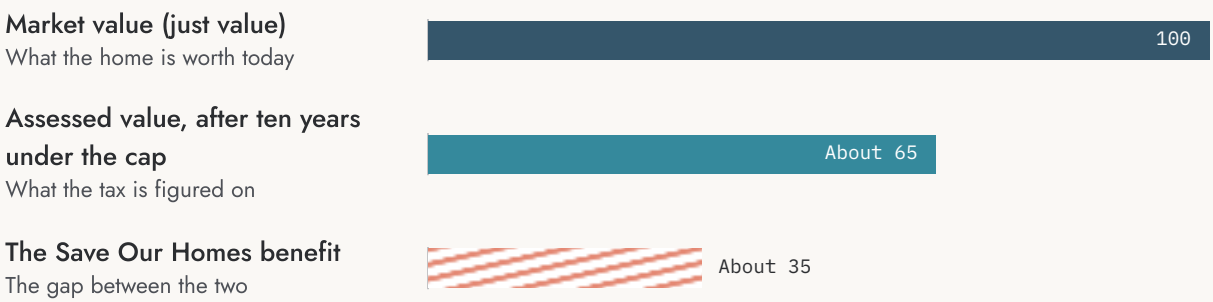
The gap between the two values is your Save Our Homes benefit. After many years of rising prices, the gap can be big. That's why the long-time owner's bill is so small.

The cap starts the year after your homestead starts. In your first year, the assessed value is the market value. From the second year on, it's capped.

FIG. 03 · TWO VALUES

Same house, two values

Each bar is one number for the same house. The gap is the owner's benefit.



These numbers are made up to show the idea. Here the market value doubled in ten years while the assessed value rose 3 percent a year. A real home has its own numbers on the appraiser's site.

Source: The rule: Florida Department of Revenue, PT-112; Florida Statutes 193.155(1). The numbers are illustrative and are not from any source

04

The reset: what happens the January after you buy

The seller's exemption and cap stay on the bill through December 31. On the next January 1, the value resets, and your own break can begin.

In the year you buy, nothing changes on the county's books. The seller's exemption and cap stay through December 31. That year's bill still carries their breaks.

On the January 1 after you buy, the appraiser takes the seller's breaks off. The assessed value becomes the market value. Live there on that January 1 and file by March 1. Then your own homestead comes off that value the same year.

Your cap begins the year after that. So your bill runs in three steps: the seller's year, the reset year, and then the capped years.

There's one way to soften the reset. If you had a Florida homestead before, you may carry part of your old cap to the new house. The next section explains.

FIG. 04 · THREE YEARS

The seller's year, the reset year, and the capped years

Read left to right from the day you buy. Each lane is one thing on the county's books.



This shows a home bought partway through a year. The exact dates depend on when you close.

Source: Florida Department of Revenue, PT-107 and PT-112; Manatee County Property Appraiser, Exemptions and Save Our Homes; Florida Statutes 193.155(1) and (3)

05

Portability: what you can carry to the next house

If you're moving from one Florida homestead to another, you can take some or all of your cap's benefit with you.

Remember the gap between the market value and the assessed value? Florida lets you move that gap to your next homestead. The state calls it portability. The most you can carry is 500,000 dollars.

There's a clock. You must set up the new homestead within three years of January 1 of the year you left the old one. The state's brochure is careful to say it's not three years from the sale date.

If the new home is worth more, you carry the whole gap, up to the limit. If it's worth less, you carry the same share of the value, not the same dollars.

FORM DR-501T

The form that moves the gap. Its full name is the Transfer of Homestead Assessment Difference. File it with your homestead application by March 1. The homestead application alone doesn't move the gap.

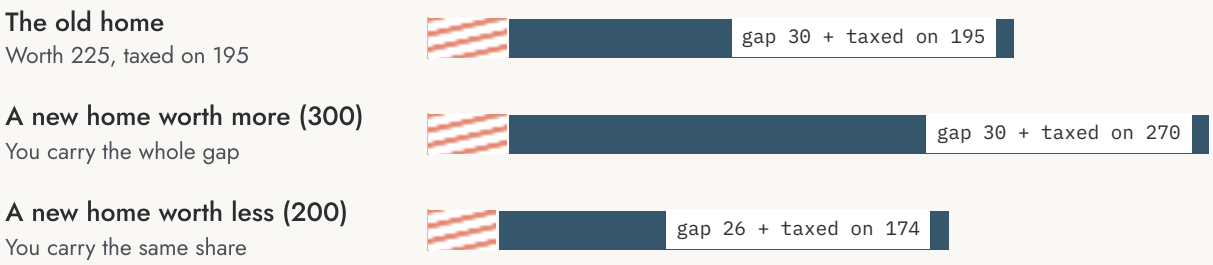
Source: Florida Department of Revenue, Transfer of Homestead Assessment Difference, form DR-501T (PDF)

The Legislature rewrote this part of the law in 2026, starting with the 2027 tax roll. The 500,000 dollar limit and the three-year clock are the same in the new text. Check the current rule the year you move.

FIG. 05 · THE COUNTY'S EXAMPLE

Carrying a 30,000 dollar gap to a new home

Each bar is a home's market value, in thousands of dollars. The hatched part at the start is the gap that isn't taxed.



The numbers come from the Manatee County appraiser's own example, in thousands of dollars. The old gap was 30,000 dollars, about 13 percent of the old home's value. Moving down, 13 percent of 200,000 is about 26,000.

Source: Manatee County Property Appraiser, Portability of Save Our Homes (the worked examples)

06

Four dates in the tax year

The property tax year runs on a few fixed dates. Knowing them tells you when your bill will change.

January 1 is the day that counts. The county values every home as of that day. It's also the day you must be living in the home to get homestead for that year.

March 1 is the last day to file for homestead, and for portability. Both counties take the application online.

In August the appraiser mails a notice of proposed property taxes. It's called the TRIM notice. It isn't a bill. It shows your value, your exemptions and the tax each local government proposes. If something looks wrong, that's the time to ask.

In November the tax collector mails the bill. You get a small discount for paying early. The taxes are due by the next March 31.

FIG. 06 · THE YEAR

The four dates on one calendar

Each numbered line is a date. The shaded part is the window for filing.



1. **January 1.** The county sets every home's value. You must live in the home on this day to get homestead for the year.
2. **March 1.** The last day to file for homestead and for portability.
3. **August.** The TRIM notice comes. It shows your value, your exemptions and the proposed tax. It isn't a bill.
4. **November.** The tax collector mails the bill. Pay early for a small discount. It's due by March 31.

The window to file for homestead, January 1 to March 1

Source: Florida Department of Revenue, Florida property tax calendar; Sarasota County Property Appraiser, Important dates; Manatee County Property Appraiser, Important dates

07

What voters decide in November 2026

A change to Florida's constitution is on the November 3, 2026 ballot. If it passes, the homestead exemption would grow a lot from 2027.

The Legislature put Amendment 3 on the ballot. It needs 60 percent of the vote to pass. Until then, the rules in this guide stand.

If it passes, the part of the exemption that skips school taxes would grow. It would be up to 150,000 dollars in 2027 and up to 250,000 dollars in 2028. The first 25,000 dollars off school taxes would stay as it is.

The cap and portability would not change. A homestead set up by someone new to Florida in 2027 or later would start smaller. We'll update this guide after the vote.

FIG. 07 · NOW AND LATER

The exemption now, and if the amendment passes

One card for each year. The cards for 2027 and 2028 apply only if 60 percent of voters say yes.

Now

THE RULES IN THIS GUIDE

The two-part exemption in section 2.

OFF SCHOOL TAXES

- The first 25,000 dollars

OFF EVERY OTHER TAX

Up to 26,411 dollars more, on value above 50,000 dollars

2027

IF THE AMENDMENT PASSES

Takes effect January 1, 2027. First seen on the August 2027 TRIM notice.

OFF SCHOOL TAXES

- The first 25,000 dollars, as now

OFF EVERY OTHER TAX

Up to 150,000 dollars

2028

IF THE AMENDMENT PASSES

The second step. Adjusted for inflation from 2029.

OFF SCHOOL TAXES

- The first 25,000 dollars, as now

OFF EVERY OTHER TAX

Up to 250,000 dollars

The county appraisers don't take sides on the amendment, and this guide doesn't either. It shows what the ballot measure says.

Source: Manatee County Property Appraiser, Proposed 2026 Florida property tax amendment FAQ; Florida House, final bill analysis, HJR 1 (2026F)

08

Before you buy: your tax homework

Five things to do, in order. The first two take ten minutes on the appraiser's website.

FIG. 08 · THE CHECKLIST

Five things to do before you buy

Go in order. Each step helps with the next one.

- ☐ 01 **Look up the home on the county appraiser's site**
  Note the market (just) value, the assessed value and the exemptions. The gap is what comes off when the home sells.
- ☐ 02 **Figure your own first full-year bill**
  Start from the market value, not the seller's bill. Take off your exemption. Some appraiser sites have a tax estimator.
- ☐ 03 **Mark March 1 on your calendar**
  File for homestead online in the first year you live there on January 1.
- ☐ 04 **If you're selling a Florida homestead, file the portability form too**
  Form DR-501T, with the homestead application, by March 1. Within three years of January 1 of the year you left the old home.
- ☐ 05 **Read the TRIM notice in August**
  Check the value and the exemptions. Ask the appraiser's office if something is missing.

Source: Each step comes from the section it sums up. The sources are listed there and at the end of this guide

If you're moving here from another Florida homestead, put the portability form on your moving list, with a date beside it.

09

Your tax notes for one house

Fill in the right side for the house you're looking at.

Address	Write it here
Market (just) value	From the appraiser's site
Assessed value	From the appraiser's site
The gap (market minus assessed)	Comes off when the home sells
The seller's exemptions	They come off too
Your first full-year bill, estimated	Market value, minus your exemption
Day to file for homestead	By March 1 of the first year
Portability form	DR-501T, if you had a Florida homestead
TRIM notice checked	August

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    laws.flrules.org/2026/239
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20. Florida House of Representatives, final bill analysis, HJR 1 (2026 special session F)
    www.flhouse.gov/Sections/Documents/loaddoc.aspx?BillNumber=1&DocumentType=Analysis&FileName=h0001z.SAC.DOCX&Session=2026F

This guide is general information about places and rules, written for Lakewood Ranch · Sarasota · Bradenton. It is not legal, insurance or tax advice, and nothing in it is a figure for any particular house.

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Send us an address.

We'll pull the appraiser's record for that house and walk through the two values and the dates with you. If you'd rather do it yourself, this guide is the order we'd do it in.

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